The purpose of mbstring, as you have no doubt figured out from the preceding section, is to provide a set of tools for safely handling multi-byte string data. It does this by providing a collection of global functions and constants. There are other extensions (which we will also be looking at shortly) designed for internationalization issues (of which encoding is just one) that provide OOP interfaces; mbstring opts for a purely functional style. (Yes, that was a deliberate pun). We've already seen the multi-byte equivalents of the core string functions, but that's only a small set of what mbstring offers. There are also functions provided for working with HTML/HTTP, regular expressions, examining string data, converting encoding, and managing program-wide settings. The functions for doing web-like things (such as MIME, HTTP, and so on) will be showcased in Chapter 11, "Programming for the Internet," and the regular-expression-specific functions are presented in the corresponding section of this chapter. (Something to look forward to!)

Configuration

The mbstring extension has a number of internal settings, each of which can be controlled through various functions or as ini file directives (each is prepended with mbstring, e.g., mbstring.detect_order):

- detect_order
- encoding_translation
- http_output_conv_mimetypes
- internal_encoding
- language
- regex_retry_limit
- regex_stack_limit
- substitute_character
- strict_detection

All of these strings exist as .ini config file entries (e.g., mb_string.language = neutral) and are also exposed via some of the functions. And the advice from me is… to leave them be, except in a few limited cases. The mbstring module on the surface looks like it offers robust internationalization but it does not. It was created primarily (by